

Setup Guide

Deploying it for the first time: from nothing, to a tablet at the gate taking real sign-ins, in about an afternoon.

For whoever is standing this up
Every step in order, with the screen you should be looking at

The order to do it in

- 1 Before you start
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Before you start

There is no account to create with anybody, no licence key and no trial. You run it, it is yours. This chapter is the shopping list.

What you need

Somewhere to run it

Either a Railway account (about ten minutes, and it handles HTTPS for you) or an always-on machine on your own network — a Mac mini, a small PC, a Raspberry Pi. Not the tablet: a tablet cannot host the server.

A tablet for the gate

An iPad is the usual choice. Any tablet with a modern browser works. One per entrance.

A stand, and power

Unglamorous and the thing most often forgotten. The tablet needs to be at standing height, and it needs a cable that will not be tripped over.

About an afternoon

Getting it running takes minutes. Deciding what you actually want to ask visitors, and finding the site rules document somebody wrote in 2019, is what takes the time.

What you do not need

- A database server. It is one file.
- A domain name, unless you want one. Railway gives you an address.
- Anybody's permission. Nothing phones home, and no visitor's data leaves your building.

DECIDE ONE THING BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Who is going to own this once it is running? Somebody has to be the account that cannot be locked out, and somebody has to notice if the backups stop. It does not have to be you, but it has to be somebody, and it is much easier to set up in their name than to hand over later.

Where it should run

Two shapes. Pick before you start, because it decides how you do the next chapter.

	RAILWAY	YOUR OWN MACHINE
Setup time	Ten minutes	Half an hour
Kiosk camera	Works straight away	Falls back to the tablet's camera app
Works if the internet drops	Kiosk keeps taking sign-ins and syncs later	Yes — it is all on your network
Data leaves the building	It sits on Railway's disk	No
Cost	A few pounds a month	The electricity
Somebody has to maintain	Almost nothing	The machine, and its backups

Most sites should start with Railway. The one strong reason to run it yourself is a policy that visitor data must not leave the premises — in which case Chapter 4 is yours.

Putting it on Railway

- 1 Push this repository to GitHub, and create a Railway project from it.
- 2 **Add a Volume and mount it at `/data`**. Do this before the first deploy finishes.
- 3 Set two variables: `NODE_ENV=production`, and `PUBLIC_URL=https://your-app.up.railway.app` — the address Railway gives you. `DATA_DIR` is not needed; a Railway volume is found automatically.
- 4 Deploy, and open the address. You should see the screen in Chapter 5.

THE VOLUME IS THE WHOLE THING

Without it, every visitor record, photo and slide is erased on your next deploy. The app will not let this be quiet about it — a banner appears in the dashboard, the sign-in screen says so, `/api/health` reports `"storage": "ephemeral"`, and the deploy log warns. If you see any of those, stop and mount the volume.

The first build is slow, on purpose

The included Dockerfile installs LibreOffice, poppler and metric-compatible fonts so that a PowerPoint induction deck renders exactly as it looks in PowerPoint. That makes the image about a gigabyte and the first build slow. If you would rather have fast builds and are happy to upload PDF exports of your decks instead, delete the Dockerfile before deploying.

Putting it on a machine of your own

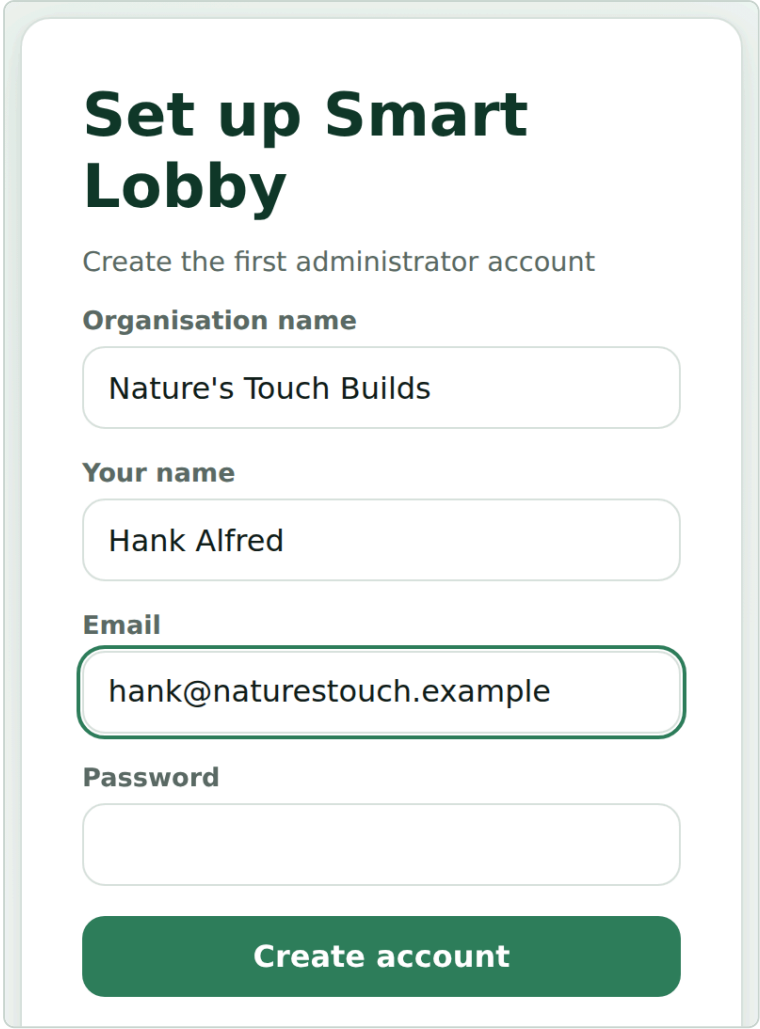
- 1 On the machine that will run it: `npm install`, then `npm start`.
- 2 Find that machine's address on the network — `ipconfig` on Windows, `ifconfig` on macOS or Linux. Something like `192.168.1.40`.
- 3 Give it a fixed address in your router, so it does not move and break every tablet.
- 4 Make sure it starts on boot. A visitor system that stops working after a power cut is not a visitor system.
- 5 Open `http://192.168.1.40:3000/admin/` from any machine on that network. You should see the screen in Chapter 5.

THE CAMERA OVER A PLAIN ADDRESS

Browsers only allow a live camera preview over `https://` or on `localhost`. Over a plain network address the kiosk automatically offers an **Open camera** button instead, which launches the tablet's own camera app — the photo is captured, cropped and attached identically. Nobody hits a dead end, but the flow is one tap longer. To get the inline preview, put a reverse proxy with a certificate in front; Caddy does it in two lines.

The first screen

A brand new install shows exactly one screen, and it is this. There is nothing to configure before it, and nothing to license.



Set up Smart Lobby

Create the first administrator account

Organisation name

Nature's Touch Builds

Your name

Hank Alfred

Email

hank@naturestouch.example

Password

Create account

The first run. The organisation name, your name, your email and a password. That is the entire installation.

The account you create here is the **owner**. It is an administrator that cannot later be demoted or deleted, because an install nobody can reach the settings on is an install nobody can fix. Only the owner can create another administrator, and only the owner can restore a backup.

PUT THE PASSWORD SOMEWHERE

There is no reset email, because there is no supplier to send one. If every login is lost, the way back in is a command run on the machine holding the data — recoverable, but not from your phone at the gate on a Monday morning. Put it in whatever your organisation uses for passwords, now, before you carry on.

From then on the same address shows an ordinary sign-in screen.

Nature's Touch Builds

Sign in to the admin dashboard

Email

Password

Sign in

Afterwards. The organisation name you typed becomes the heading, so people can see they are in the right place.

What you are looking at

Dashboard
Live view of who is on site right now.

Storage is 88% full — 29.6 GB left. When it fills, sign-ins stop and no backup can be written. What is using it is under **Settings → Backups**; shortening how long photos are kept under **Data retention** is usually the quickest room to find.

No backup has ever been written. One should be written every night — check **Settings → Backups**.

1 On site now

0 Still expected today

0 Signed in today

0 Signed out today

0 Parcels waiting

0 Inductions today

4 People on file

On site now (1) Emergency roll call Sign out everyone

	NAME	COMPANY	TYPE	STAFF MEMBER	BADGE	SINCE	
	Jane Doe	Example Roofing	contractor			20:06	Badge Sign out

Last 14 days

Recent deliveries

No deliveries logged yet.

30

Day one. Not an empty screen: a fresh install seeds one worked example per visitor type, so you can see what a visit, a contractor sign-in, an interview and a driver record actually look like before you have any of your own.

The menu down the left is the whole system. Roughly, top to bottom:

Dashboard, Expected, Visits, Registry

What is happening and what has happened. Reception lives here.

Drivers, Deliveries

Trucks and parcels, if you have them.

Staff, Companies, Certificates, Projects

The lists everything else refers to.

Sign-in setup

What the kiosk asks and shows: induction decks, documents, visitor types, badges.

Reports

Visits, hours per project, and a printable version.

Settings

Everything else, one page per entry — branding, the form, notifications, devices, doors, backups, accounts.

EVERYTHING SAVES ITSELF

The settings pages have no Save button. A change is written as you make it, and a small *Saved* pill confirms it. If you are used to hunting for a save button, you are not missing one.

Leave the examples where they are for now. Chapter 22 clears them, once you have something of your own to look at.

Step one — the name, the logo and the clock

Settings → Branding. Twenty minutes here is the difference between a kiosk that looks like your site and one that looks like a demo.

Organisation name
Nature's Touch Builds

Kiosk headline
Welcome to Nature's Touch Bu

Kiosk sub-heading
Please sign in — it takes about

Sign-out message
Thanks for visiting. Travel safe!

Headline en español
Bienvenido

Sub-heading en español

Sign-out en español

Primary colour

Dark accent colour

Time zone
America/Los Angeles

Phone number format
United States — (555) 123-4

Date format
UK — 25 Aug 2026, 14:30

LOGO
Shown on the kiosk welcome screen, the badges, this dashboard and the sign-in page.
Upload logo No logo set — PNG or SVG with a transparent background works best

WELCOME TEXT POSITION
Move the headline, sub-heading and button clear of whatever is in your background photo. The preview below updates as you change it.

Across
Centre

Down
Middle

☐ Show the time and organisation name along the bottom of the welcome screen

KIOSK BACKGROUND
Photos behind the welcome screen — site shots or finished builds work well. Landscape, at least 1600px wide. Add several and the kiosk fades between them. Leave it empty for the plain gradient.
Upload photos No photos yet — you can select several at once

Welcome to Nature's Touch Builds

Branding. The name, the wording on the kiosk, two colours, the logo, background photos, and the time zone. The preview beside it mirrors the tablet.

Do the time zone now

This is the one setting that is painful to change later. It is the site's own time zone, and everything that names a day or a time uses it: the date on a badge and inside the badge number, the "today" counts, the charts, and every arrival time on the dashboard.

SET IT BEFORE ANYBODY SIGNS IN

Times are stored as UTC, so changing the zone later re-reads all your existing history in the new one rather than shifting it — which is correct, but means yesterday's badge numbers no longer match yesterday's dates. Set it now and leave it alone unless the site itself moves.

The logo and the background

A PNG or SVG with a transparent background works best; it appears on the kiosk, on printed badges, in the dashboard sidebar and on the sign-in page.

For the background you can set one photo or several that crossfade on a timer. A slider controls how much they are darkened so the welcome text stays readable, with a live preview beside it. Landscape, 1600px wide or more. Leave it empty for a plain gradient — which looks perfectly fine, and is better than a stretched photo.

Step two — the people visitors ask for

Staff is the list a visitor picks from when the kiosk asks who they are here to see. Nothing else works properly until this has real people in it.

Staff

The people visitors can ask for. An email address is all most of them need — it is what lets Smart Lobby tag them in your Teams channel when their visitor arrives.

Name
Email
Mobile (for SMS)
Department

Add staff member

► **A PERSONAL CHAT LINK** Only for somebody who is not in your Teams channel

NAME	EMAIL	MOBILE	DEPARTMENT	DASHBOARD ACCESS	STATUS
Ellie Sharpe	ellie.sharpe@naturestouch.example	415-268-0144	People	No login	active Edit Give a login Remove
Marcus Ojo	marcus.ojo@naturestouch.example	415-268-0143	Facilities	No login	active Edit Give a login Remove
Dana Whitlock	dana.whitlock@naturestouch.example	415-268-0142	Health & safety	No login	active Edit Give a login Remove
Tom Beckett	tom.beckett@naturestouch.example	415-268-0141	Groundworks	No login	active Edit Give a login Remove
Priya Raman	priya.raman@naturestouch.example	415-268-0140	Site management	No login	active Edit Give a login Remove

Dashboard access is separate from being someone a visitor can ask for. A staff member with no login simply never signs in here.

Add several at once from a spreadsheet

Upload an Excel file (.xlsx) or a .csv. The first row should be headings — *First name, Last name, Email, Phone, Department, Chat webhook*. Only the name is required, and headings can be worded your way: a single *Full name* column works just as well as separate first and last, and "Mobile", "Surname", "Team" and similar are all understood.

Someone already on the list is updated rather than duplicated, matched on email, or on name when there is no email — so you can fix a sheet and upload it again.

Choose spreadsheet
Download a template

Staff. Each person can carry an email address, a mobile number and their own chat webhook, so an arrival reaches them rather than a shared inbox.

Add them from a spreadsheet

Do not type forty people in by hand. Upload an `.xlsx` or `.csv`: the first row should be headings, first and last name in separate columns or one full-name column. Only the name is required, and headings are matched loosely, so "Full name", "Phone", "Mobile" and "Team" all work. A template is downloadable from that panel.

Somebody already on the list is updated rather than duplicated — matched on email, or on name where there is no email — so a corrected sheet can simply be uploaded again.

EMAIL ADDRESSES ARE WORTH CHASING

Somebody with no email cannot be notified, and cannot be @-mentioned in a Teams message — a mention Teams cannot resolve renders as raw markup, so it is left off instead. Get the addresses in now.

Step three — the jobs, if you run contractors

Skip this chapter if nobody signs in against a job.

Projects

The jobs a contractor can be on site for. They pick one from this list when they sign in, so a report of who worked on what stays clean. Give a project a Spanish name and the kiosk shows it when switched to Spanish; leave it empty and the English one is shown.

Project name

En español (optional)

Code (optional)

Riverside build

Obra de Riverside

RB-24

Add project

PROJECT	EN ESPAÑOL	CODE	ON SITE NOW	VISITS	STATUS	
Office fit-out		OF3	2	2	active	Edit Remove
Warehouse extension		WX1	4	6	active	Edit Remove
Yard resurfacing		YR2	3	4	active	Edit Remove

A finished job is closed with **Edit → Active off** — it drops off the kiosk but keeps its history. A project that has ever been signed in against cannot be removed, only closed.

Projects. Each with a name, an optional Spanish name and a short code. Contractors pick one at sign-in.

The project lands on the visit record, in the visits export, and — the part most sites are actually after — drives **hours on site per project** on the reports. If you want that figure, set the project field to *required* for contractors in the next chapter but one.

Close a finished job by switching **Active** off: it disappears from the kiosk but keeps its history. A project that has ever been signed in against cannot be deleted, only closed.

Step four — the cards on the kiosk

Sign-in setup → **Visitor types** decides what a visitor sees when they walk up to the tablet.

Visitor types

The cards on the kiosk. Each type has its own wording, its own place on the home screen, and — via the other tabs — its own documents, induction, form fields and step order. Add one here and it appears everywhere a type can be chosen: the “Your details” form settings, document and deck assignment, and the per-device card list.

On the kiosk

Home screen

As it looks right now, before saving

Sign in
Visitors & contractors

Sign out
Leaving site

Interview
Here to meet the hiring team

Delivery
Courier drop-off

After tapping **Sign in** — “What brings you here today?”

Visitor

Contractor

Interview

Drag a card to change the order they appear in on the kiosk. The fixed cards — Sign in, Sign out, Delivery — keep their places.

Visitor

Behind the Sign in

Line under the name (optional)

Name en español (optional)

Line under the name en español (optional)

Key: visitor

Contractor

Behind the Sign in

Visitor types. The list on one side, a live preview of the kiosk home screen on the other. Drag the preview to change the order the tablet shows them in.

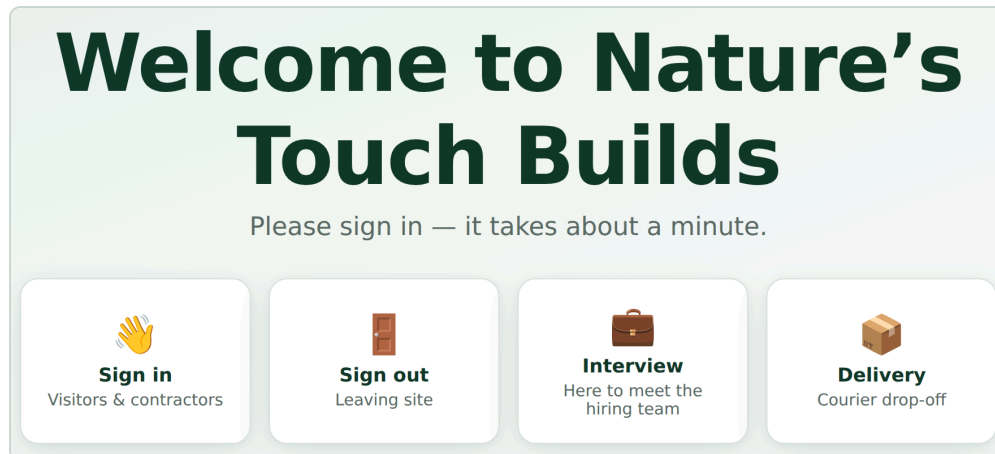
Each type carries a name in both languages, an icon, and where it appears: its own card on the home screen, an option behind **Sign in**, both, or hidden. Press the icon to open a picker of emoji chosen for the job — things that read as a delivery driver from six feet away.

What most sites end up with

- **Sign in** and **Sign out** — always.
- **Contractor** as its own card if you have a crew: it goes straight into a contractor sign-in with no picker in between.
- **Driver** if trucks come to a gate. It asks for the haulier, vehicle, docket and whether they are delivering or collecting, and never asks who they are visiting.
- **Delivery** if couriers leave parcels at reception.

- **Interview** if you want candidates recorded separately from visitors — which HR usually does.

Add your own if none of those fit. A new type immediately gains its own form settings, document assignments, induction targeting and per-device placement.



What that produces. Open `/kiosk/` in another tab while you work — it reloads itself within about twenty seconds of any change you save.

Step five — what you ask people

Settings → **Visitor form** is a grid: the fields down the side, your visitor types across the top. Every cell is *off*, *optional* or *required*.

What each type of visitor is asked. An interview does not need a reason for visit — the card already says why they are here — so switch it off in that column alone.

Field	Visitor	Contractor	Interview	Driver
Photo Needs https:// for the camera to open Turn off for everyone	Optional	Optional	Required	Optional
Company Turn off for everyone	Optional	Required	Not asked	Required
Phone number Also used to recognise returning visitors Turn off for everyone	Required	Required	Required	Required
Email address Turn off for everyone	Not asked	Not asked	Optional	Not asked
Who they are seeing Turn off for everyone	Required	Not asked	Required	Not asked
Reason for visit Turn off for everyone	Optional	Not asked	Not asked	Not asked
Vehicle registration Turn off for everyone	Not asked	Not asked	Not asked	Required
Load or order reference Order, docket or PO number Turn off for everyone	Not asked	Not asked	Not asked	Required
Pick-Up or Delivery Turn off for everyone	Not asked	Not asked	Not asked	Required
Project Picked from the list on the Projects tab Turn off for everyone	Not asked	Required	Not asked	Not asked
Scan a driver's licence Reads the barcode on the back of a US or Canadian licence and records the name, licence number and issuing state — nothing else off the card. Needs	Not asked	Not asked	Not asked	Not asked

The form, per type. Hovering highlights the whole row and the whole column, so you can see which field and which type a dropdown belongs to before changing it.

Ask for less than you think

Every field is another thing somebody types one-handed with a queue behind them. A useful default:

FIELD	VISITOR	CONTRACTOR	DRIVER
Photo	Optional	Optional	Off
Company	Optional	Required	Required
Phone	Required	Required	Optional
Who they are seeing	Required	Off	Off
Project	Off	Required	Off
Vehicle, docket, in or out	Off	Off	Required

Under **Wordings** you can rename a field per type — a driver is asked for a haulier, not a company — and add a line of help underneath it.

THE PHONE NUMBER EARNS ITS PLACE

It is how a returning visitor is recognised, and how somebody booked in advance is matched to their booking. A site that does not collect it makes every visitor a stranger every time.

Step six — the sign-in flow

HOW CHECK-IN WORKS

Finding the visitor always comes first — it decides whether they need the induction at all. Everything after that is yours to arrange, and it can differ per type. A step that does not apply is skipped wherever it sits: no photo asked for, no documents for that type, an induction already watched.

Flow for

Visitor

START → 1 Their details → 2 Photo → 3 Documents & questions → 4 Induction deck → DONE

Drag a step to move it, or use the arrows on it.

► **EVERY TYPE SIDE BY SIDE** The same order, all four at once

BEHAVIOUR

☒ Skip "Touch to start"
Put the sections straight on the home screen

☐ Show how many people are on site

☒ Let returning visitors find themselves by name
They pick from matching names. Only a name and company are shown, never a phone number or email

☒ Let visitors scan their badge to sign out
Only useful with badge printing on, and its QR code switched on

☒ Sign everyone out at the end of the day
People forget to sign out, and a roll call is worthless with yesterday's visitors still on it

Return to the welcome screen after (seconds)

90

Hold the thank-you screen for (seconds)

12

Sign everyone out at

The kiosk flow. Whether the cards sit on the welcome screen or behind a "Touch to start" button, whether Spanish is offered, how long before it times out, and what time anybody left on site is signed out.

Three settings here are worth a moment:

Offer Spanish

Turns on an **English / Español** bar on the welcome screen and a small button in the corner of every later screen. The kiosk's own wording is already translated; anything you type gets a Spanish box beside it, and an empty one falls back to English.

Time out back to the welcome screen

90 seconds by default. An abandoned sign-in is wiped completely when it fires — every field, the photo, the answers — so nothing of one visitor is left on screen for the next.

Sign out anyone left on site at

23:59 by default, in your time zone. People forget to sign out, and a roll call full of people who went home on Tuesday is worse than useless.

The order the four sign-in steps are asked in — details, photo, documents, induction — is set per visitor type under

Settings → The order things are asked. A contractor can watch the induction before signing anything while visitors keep the usual order.

Step seven — documents to sign

Documents to sign

NDAs, site rules and safety declarations. Each one is assigned to the categories that must sign it, and can ask its own questions before the signature. Deliveries do not sign anything.

New document

Site safety rules & confidentiality active

v1 · signed by Visitor, Contractor, Interview · every visit

Edit

Delete

While on site you agree to:

- Report to your host and remain with them in operational areas.
- Wear the PPE provided and follow all safety signage.
- Follow the fire evacuation procedure and assemble at the muster point.
- Keep confidential any information you see or hear during your visit.
- Report any accident, near miss or hazard to reception immediately.

Documents. Each is assigned to the visitor types that must sign it, and carries its own version.

A document is either wording you type here, or an uploaded **PDF or Word file** — which is what most sites want, because the site rules already exist as a document somebody spent a long time on. Save the document first, then reopen it and use **Upload PDF or Word**.

The file is rendered to page images, so it reads on the kiosk exactly as it was drafted. The layout of a safety document is part of what is being agreed to.

Questions

A document can carry its own questions, asked just above the signature: yes/no, a short answer, or a choice from your own options. A question can depend on an earlier answer — *Only ask this if* — so a No opens one follow-up and a Yes opens another.

A document with questions and the signature switched off is a questionnaire: the visitor answers and carries on. Useful for a health declaration where a signature adds nothing.

VERSIONS PROTECT YOU

Editing a document, or uploading a new file, bumps its version. Copies already signed stay exactly as they were signed, and each signature records the version and the language on screen at the time — so it is always known which wording somebody actually agreed to.

Step eight — the induction

Induction decks

Upload a PowerPoint, PDF or images. First-time visitors watch it before they finish signing in; people who have already seen the current version skip straight through.

This server cannot render PowerPoint properly. Missing: poppler (pdftoppm). Decks are rebuilt from their text and images instead, which loses the original layout, fonts and colours.
Deploy with the included `Dockerfile` to get both, or export your deck to PDF and upload that instead — a PDF keeps the original look.

New deck

No induction decks yet. Create one, then upload your PowerPoint.

Induction decks. Create a deck, drop a PowerPoint, PDF or images onto it, and assign it to the visitor types that must watch it.

First-time visitors always watch it. Returning visitors only watch it again if the deck version changed, or you set "repeat after N days", or you tick "show it every visit". Uploading a new file replaces the slides and bumps the version, which is deliberate: everyone sees the new induction once, including people who watched the old one.

UPLOAD A PDF IF THE LAYOUT MATTERS

PowerPoint shrinks text that overflows its box and stores only the shrink factor; the renderer on the server ignores it and draws the text full size, so a tight slide comes out with words under the pictures. Nothing on the server can undo that. **File** →

Export → **PDF** bakes the layout in, and the PDF is still split into slides, so nothing else about the deck changes. Always check with **Preview** after uploading.

If you need proof people actually read it, set **minimum seconds per slide**:

Next shows a countdown and only unlocks when the time is up. Completion is stored per person with the version and the seconds taken, and appears on the visit record.

Step nine — badges, if you print them

Off by default, and plenty of sites never turn it on. Skip this chapter if you do not have a label printer.

Badges

What a printed badge shows, the label it prints on, and reprinting one that has been lost.

☒ **Print a badge when someone signs in**
 Leave this off if no label printer is connected — everything else works either way

☐ **Print automatically**
 Off means the visitor taps “Print badge” themselves

Label size

Label stock

Brother DK-11202 — 62 × 100 mm

Width (mm) 62 **Height (mm)** 100

Which way it prints on the label

Vertical — reads down the label

The label itself does not change size; the badge is turned on it

Text size — 1×

WORDING

Header

VISITOR

Footer

Please return this badge on exit

BADGE NUMBERS

Every badge gets a number, counted fresh each day. What that number looks like is up to you.

Prefix Counter digits

What the badge shows

☒ Logo
☒ Photo
☒ Company
☒ Who they are visiting
☒ Date
☒ Time
☒ Badge number
☒ QR code
 Scannable at the kiosk to sign out

The badge designer. A live preview at the real label size, a test print, and reprinting for anybody from the last week.

- 1 Connect the label printer to the tablet that shows the kiosk — USB, or a network/AirPrint printer — and make it that device’s default printer.
- 2 Set the label size to match your stock. 62 × 100 mm is a common Brother size.
- 3 In the browser’s print settings: margins **None**, headers and footers **off**, background graphics **on**.
- 4 Print a test badge and adjust the width, height and text scale until it lines up.

The badge number is built from tokens, with a live sample as you type. The default `{prefix}{yy}{mm}{dd}-{seq}` gives `NTB260830-004`. You can set a different prefix per visitor type so contractors and drivers run separate series.

BLUETOOTH PRINTERS WILL NOT WORK

iPads print over Bluetooth only from the manufacturer's own app, never from a web page. A Bluetooth-only printer cannot print badges here. Network or Wireless Direct is what you need.

Step ten — telling somebody a visitor arrived

Until you do this, arrivals are recorded and shown on the dashboard but nobody is told. That is a perfectly reasonable place to start; it is also the thing most sites want most.

MICROSOFT TEAMS

Arrivals go to one Teams channel, and the person being visited is tagged in the post using the email on their **Staff** record — so they get a notification without anybody setting up a link of their own. A staff member who wants their own direct message can still paste a personal Teams link on their record.

☒ **Post every arrival to the company channel**
With this off, the channel is only used for people who have no Teams link of their own

Company channel link

Format for unrecognised URLs

Microsoft Teams

A Teams, Slack or Google Chat link is recognised on sight; this only applies to anything else.

▼ **Getting the Teams link for a channel**

1. In Teams, hover the channel → ... → **Workflows**.
2. Choose the template **“Post to a channel when a webhook request is received”**.
3. Name it “Smart Lobby”, confirm the team and channel, then **Add workflow**.
4. Copy the HTTPS URL it shows — you only get it once — and paste it above.
5. Save, then press **Send test to Teams** below.

For an individual person, the same thing with the *chat* template, pasted into their record on the **Staff** tab. Full instructions for both, including what to do when your tenant hides the chat template, are on that tab under **Setting up a chat webhook**.

WHAT THE MESSAGE LOOKS LIKE

Four different things get announced, and they are not the same kind of message — an arrival wants a face and a project, a sign-out wants a time, a parcel has no visitor on it at all. Each gets its own design. The preview is built by the same code that sends the real thing, so what you see here is what lands in the channel.

Sign-ins

Sign-outs

Finished site induction

Parcel arrives

When a visitor signs in at the kiosk

Every type

Visitor

Contractor

Interview

Driver

This is the card every visitor type gets. Pick a type above to give that one its own.

Heading colour

Details layout

Preview

Blue

Two columns — label beside value

Teams only offers its own palette, so this is a choice rather than a colour picker

Notifications. Six channels, each switchable on its own, each with a test button that can only ever reach your own address.

CHANNEL	WHAT IT NEEDS	EFFORT
Microsoft Teams	A Workflows URL	Ten minutes, no admin consent
Slack	An incoming webhook URL	Five minutes
Google Chat	An incoming webhook URL	Five minutes
Email	SMTP host, port, user, password	Depends on your mail provider
SMS	A Twilio account	Twenty minutes, and it costs per text
Generic JSON	Any URL you control	For driving something else

Start with one. Teams or Slack is the usual answer, because the message can tag the person being visited and they are already looking at it.

Two places at once

Chat notifications go to a **company channel** that sees every arrival, and to each person's **own webhook** for their own visitors. Switch the channel off being always-on and it becomes a fallback for people who have no webhook of their own.

What the message looks like

anybody setting up a link of their own. A staff member who wants their own direct message can still paste a personal Teams link on their record.

☒ **Post every arrival to the company channel**
With this off, the channel is only used for people who have no Teams link of their own

Company channel link

Format for unrecognised URLs
Microsoft Teams
A Teams, Slack or Google Chat link is recognised on sight; this only applies to anything else.

▼ **Getting the Teams link for a channel**

1. In Teams, hover the channel → ... → **Workflows**.
2. Choose the template **"Post to a channel when a webhook request is received"**.
3. Name it "Smart Lobby", confirm the team and channel, then **Add workflow**.
4. Copy the HTTPS URL it shows — you only get it once — and paste it above.
5. Save, then press **Send test to Teams** below.

For an individual person, the same thing with the *chat* template, pasted into their record on the **Staff** tab. Full instructions for both, including what to do when your tenant hides the chat template, are on that tab under **Setting up a chat webhook**.

WHAT THE MESSAGE LOOKS LIKE

Four different things get announced, and they are not the same kind of message — an arrival wants a face and a project, a sign-out wants a time, a parcel has no visitor on it at all. Each gets its own design. The preview is built by the same code that sends the real thing, so what you see here is what lands in the channel.

Sign-ins Sign-outs Finished site induction Parcel arrives

When a visitor signs in at the kiosk

Every type Visitor Contractor Interview Driver

This is the card every visitor type gets. Pick a type above to give that one its own.

Heading colour
Blue

Details layout
Two columns — label beside value

Teams only offers its own palette, so this is a choice rather than a colour picker

Heading
{name} has arrived to see {host}

Under the heading
{company}

Footer

Preview

Sami Haddad has arrived to see Ellie Sharpe
@Ellie Sharpe — your visitor is here.

Visitor type Interview
Here to see Ellie Sharpe
Badge NTB260830-007
Time 30/08/2026, 14:13:00

Nature's Touch Builds · Smart Lobby

The card designer. Title, fields, photo size and placement, colours and footer — separately for arrivals, departures, finished inductions and parcels, with a live preview.

You do not have to touch any of this to get working notifications; the defaults are sensible. Come back to it once arrivals are flowing.

TEST MESSAGES CANNOT REACH A REAL PERSON

Every test goes to the address in **Send test emails to** and nowhere else. You cannot accidentally send a test arrival to your whole company channel while setting it up.

Step eleven — registering the tablet

Devices

Every tablet or screen running Smart Lobby. Register one here, then open its link on the device and add it to the home screen.

No locations yet — add them under **Locations** first so each device can say where it is.

Device name

Reception iPad

Location

— none —

Register device

No devices registered yet.

Devices. Register each tablet, and it gets its own address with a one-press copy button.

Register the tablet here before you touch the tablet itself. It gets:

- **Its own URL** — `/kiosk/north-gate-ipad` . Because the device is named in the address, a home-screen icon always comes back as that device.
- **Its own cards, in its own order**, independently of every other tablet. The gate tablet can show Contractor and Driver; the reception one can show Visitor and Delivery.
- A location, a printer, a default camera, and whether it prints badges at all.
- An online status, from a heartbeat every minute — so you can see from your desk that the gate tablet has been off since Thursday.

Press **Copy link** and send it to yourself; you will need it in a moment.

Step twelve — setting up the tablet itself

- 1 Open the device's own link in the tablet's browser — Safari on an iPad.
- 2 Share → **Add to Home Screen**. Launched from the home screen it runs full screen with no browser chrome.
- 3 Sign in once as a visitor yourself, and allow the camera when it asks.
- 4 Turn on **Guided Access** (Settings → Accessibility) so visitors cannot leave the app. Set a passcode you will remember.
- 5 Set the tablet never to sleep, and to auto-lock never, while it is on charge.

Your details Back

Full name *

Wanda Achebe

Company

Redgate Insurance

Phone number *

(415) 268-3000

Which member of staff are you here to see? *

Start typing a name...

Reason for visit

Insurance renewal

Nature's Touch Builds records your name and the details you enter and a photograph, so we know who is on site for safety and fire roll call. We keep records for 730 days. Ask at reception for a copy of your details or to have them removed.

Continue

What a visitor sees. The fields you chose in Chapter 11, worded how you worded them, with your own privacy note at the foot.

IF NO CAMERA PROMPT EVER APPEARS

A third-party kiosk browser must both hold the camera permission itself *and* forward the page's request. Ones that skip the second part deny it silently, with no prompt at all. Open `/check/` on that tablet — it reports what that browser actually allows. Safari with Guided Access is the reliable alternative.

Step thirteen — backups, before you need them

One ZIP holding the database **and** every uploaded file — visitor photos, signatures, deck slides, your logo — written every night, the last seven kept. Each one is opened and checked after it is written, because an unverified backup is a guess.

They sit on the same volume as the live data, so on their own they answer “something corrupted the database” and not “the volume is gone”. **Download one and keep it somewhere else** — that is the copy that survives losing the machine.

Back up now 1 kept, 28 kB in total

TAKEN	SIZE	HOLDS	
30 Aug, 16:07	28 kB	Database and files	Test Download Delete

ROOM ON THE DISK

When this fills, sign-ins stop and no backup can be written — including the one that would have told you.

88% of 258019.6 MB used — 30290.5 MB left.

Photos and signatures — 25 files	13 kB
Database	3.3 MB
Backups kept here — 1 files	28 kB

Photos alone are 11 kB across 22 files. How long they are kept is set under **Data retention & privacy**; shortening it is usually the quickest room to find.

When it gets tight

Rather than let the disk fill and take the kiosk down with it, the oldest photos can be dropped early. They are the least useful thing on the disk and by far the largest — and losing one costs a look-up nobody was going to do, against a site that stops taking sign-ins.

☒ Drop the oldest photos before the disk fills

Start when the disk is this full (%) Clear back down to (%) Never touch photos newer than (days)

Free up room now Has not needed to run — it starts at 90% full.

COPY EACH BACKUP TO ONEDRIVE

A backup sitting on the same volume as the data does not survive losing the volume. This posts each new one straight into a OneDrive folder as it is written, so there is always a copy somewhere else without anybody remembering to do anything.

Backups. A nightly archive of the database and every uploaded file, seven kept, each integrity-checked after it is written.

The nightly backup runs on its own from the moment you install, so there is nothing to switch on. Two things are worth doing today.

Turn on the off-site copy

Backups sit on the same volume as the data, so on their own they answer “something corrupted the database” and not “the volume is gone”. Posting each new one straight into a **OneDrive** folder is what makes a copy survive losing the machine. The destination is a Power Automate flow — “When an HTTP request is received” → “Create file” — which needs no Azure app registration and no admin consent. Step-by-step instructions are on that page.

Press Test on a backup

A backup nobody has ever opened is a promise, not a copy. **Test** opens one, reads the database inside it, and says whether it would actually restore — schema, accounts, and whether the photos the records point at are really in the archive. It changes nothing. Do it now, so you know what a good answer looks like.

88% of 258019.6 MB used — 30285.6 MB left.

Photos and signatures — 25 files	13 kB
Database	3.4 MB
Backups kept here — 1 files	28 kB

Photos alone are 11 kB across 22 files. How long they are kept is set under **Data retention & privacy**; shortening it is usually the quickest room to find.

When it gets tight
Rather than let the disk fill and take the kiosk down with it, the oldest photos can be dropped early. They are the least useful thing on the disk and by far the largest — and losing one costs a look-up nobody was going to do, against a site that stops taking sign-ins.

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COPY EACH BACKUP TO ONEDRIVE
A backup sitting on the same volume as the data does not survive losing the volume. This posts each new one straight into a OneDrive folder as it is written, so there is always a copy somewhere else without anybody remembering to do anything.

Room on the disk. What is using the volume, and roughly how long the space left will last at the rate this site fills it.

Photos are what fill a disk. The pressure valve — under **When it gets tight** — drops the oldest photos before the volume fills, never inside a floor window and never quietly. Leave it on; a full disk stops sign-ins altogether.

And decide how long you keep things

Delete visit records after (days) Delete visitor photos after (days) Clear scanned ID details after (days)

A licence number is the most identifying thing here and is useful for far less time than the visit it sits on. Clearing it empties the three ID fields and leaves the rest of the visit alone.

WHAT THE KIOSK TELLS VISITORS

☒ Show a privacy note on the details screen
Under the form that asks, not buried in a document nobody reads

Wording

Left empty, the kiosk shows a note built from what you actually ask for and how long you keep it — so it cannot claim to take a photo on a kiosk that never asks for one.

Wording en español

On the kiosk, visitors see:

Nature's Touch Builds records your name and the details you enter and a photograph, so we know who is on site for safety and fire roll call. We keep records for 730 days. Ask at reception for a copy of your details or to have them removed.

Data retention. Three separate windows — photos, licence details and visit records — plus the privacy notice the kiosk shows.

The defaults are 90 days for photos, 180 for licence details and two years for visit records. If your organisation has a retention policy, this is where it goes, and it is much easier to set now than to explain later.

Chapter 20

Step fourteen — logins for everyone else

YOUR ACCOUNT
Signed in as **Hank Alfred**. Changing your password signs out any other browser signed in as you.

Current password

New password

New password again

Change password

EVERYONE WITH A LOGIN

Hank Alfred
hankalfr@gmail.com

owner

you

Name

Email

Password

Add user

Nobody can sign in at all? There is no reset email to send — run `node scripts/reset-password.js you@example.com 'a new password'` on the server holding the data. On Railway that is a one-off command against this service.

Accounts. A login is granted against somebody who is already on the staff list, at one of four levels.

LEVEL	GIVE IT TO
Reception	The front desk. Visits, expected, the registry, projects and reports.
Clerk	Whoever handles trucks and parcels, and nothing else.
Manager	Both of the above together. Not the settings.
Administrator	Everything, including settings, backups and accounts. Only the owner can grant it.

Give people their own login rather than sharing one. Every action is recorded against whoever was signed in, and an audit log that names the wrong person is worse than no audit log.

PASSWORDS YOU SET ARE TEMPORARY

A password set by somebody else can do exactly two things until it is changed: show who the account is, and change its password. So handing somebody a password does not leave you able to sign in as them afterwards.

The dress rehearsal

Half an hour, before anybody real walks up to it. Every one of these has caught something on a real install.

- 1 **Sign yourself in at the tablet**, as a visitor, exactly as a visitor would. Do not skip the photo.
- 2 **Check the notification arrived** where you expected it, tagging the right person. If not, open the visit and read the notification log at the foot of the record.
- 3 **Check the dashboard** shows you on site, with the right time in the right time zone.
- 4 **Print a badge**, if you print badges. Look at whether it lines up on the label.
- 5 **Sign out** — first by holding the badge to the scanner, then by name for somebody without one.
- 6 **Sign in as a contractor**, pick a project, and watch the induction the whole way through. Time it. If it takes four minutes, your crew will hate it at seven in the morning.
- 7 **Sign in as the same person again** and confirm they are recognised and skip the induction.
- 8 **Pull the network cable**, or turn off the tablet's wifi, and sign somebody in offline. Put it back and confirm the sign-in appears.
- 9 **Run an emergency roll call** and print it. Know where that button is before you need it.
- 10 **Press Test on a backup.**

Sign out

Back

Search for yourself by first name, last name or phone number, then tap your name.

First name, last name or phone number

Open the badge scanner

No matching visitor is signed in.

Signing out. The scanner is already running when the screen opens; the name search underneath is for anybody without a badge.

Going live

- 1 **Clear the examples.** The four sample records a fresh install ships with are cleared from the dashboard in one press. They are flagged in the database rather than matched by name, so clearing them can never touch a real visitor who happens to share one.
- 2 **Book in tomorrow's visitors** under **Expected today**, so the first morning demonstrates the thing at its best: somebody walks up, types their number, and the form is already filled in.
- 3 **Tell reception it exists** and hand them the Front Desk Guide.
- 4 **Put a sign on the tablet.** "Please sign in here" in your own words does more for adoption than anything in this guide.
- 5 **Stand next to it for the first hour.** You will learn more about your own configuration in that hour than in a week of settings pages.

Expected

Book somebody in before they arrive and the kiosk knows them: their details are already filled in, and reception can answer "who is coming today" without asking around.

mm/dd/yyyy

Any status

Everything ahead

Book somebody in

Today: 3 still to come, 0 arrived.

WHEN	NAME	COMPANY	TYPE	SEEING	CODE	STATUS		
30 Aug 2026 14:30	Wanda Achebe	Redgate Insurance	visitor	Dana Whitlock	Q9CPKN	Due	Edit	Remove
30 Aug 2026 15:00	Xavier Boucher	Aurora Fire Systems	contractor		7U8JJC	Due	Edit	Remove
30 Aug 2026 16:00	Yara Salim		interview	Ellie Sharpe	2BR2NF	Due	Edit	Remove
31 Aug 2026 09:00	Zoë Lindqvist	Ashcroft Surveying	visitor	Priya Raman	QL9K2H	Due	Edit	Remove

Expected today. Booking people in before the first morning is the cheapest way to make the system look like it was worth installing.

The first week

Five things to look at, once a day, for the first week.

Is anybody still on site who went home?

If the same names appear every evening, sign-out is not sticking. Put a Sign out card on the home screen, or make the badge scanner the first thing people see.

Did the notifications land?

Settings → **Notifications** → **What has been sent** lists the last fifty attempts with the reason for any failure.

Is the induction too long?

The visit record stores how many seconds each person took. If everybody is at the minimum, they are waiting rather than reading.

Are companies arriving spelled three ways?

Companies flags near-duplicates and offers to merge them. Ten minutes in the first week saves a messy report later.

Did last night's backup run?

The Backups page lists them with the time. If the newest is three days old, something is wrong now rather than on the day you need it.

Dashboard

Live view of who is on site right now.

Storage is 88% full — 29.6 GB left. When it fills, sign-ins stop and no backup can be written. What is using it is under **Settings** → **Backups**; shortening how long photos are kept under **Data retention** is usually the quickest room to find.

No backup has ever been written. One should be written every night — check **Settings** → **Backups**.

14

On site now

3

Still expected today

22

Signed in today

8

Signed out today

3

Parcels waiting

0

Inductions today

22

People on file

On site now (14)

Emergency roll call

Sign out everyone

	NAME	COMPANY	TYPE	STAFF MEMBER	BADGE	SINCE		
SH	Sami Haddad 4152682019		interview	Ellie Sharpe	NTB260830-007	14:13	Badge	Sign out
VI	Viktor Ilić 4152682022	Longhaul Logistics	driver		T260830-003	13:34	Badge	Sign out
QM	Quentin Marsh 4152682017	Northgate Roofing	visitor	Tom Beckett	NTB260830-005	11:59	Badge	Sign out
OB	Orla Brennan 4152682015	Redgate Insurance	visitor	Dana Whitlock	NTB260830-003	10:45	Badge	Sign out
MO	Marguerite Oyelaran 4152682013	Ashcroft Surveying	visitor	Priya Raman	NTB260830-001	09:31	Badge	Sign out
KL	Kasia Lewandowska 4152682011	Vega Electrical	contractor		C260830-011	09:17	Badge	Sign out
GO	Grace Okonkwo 4152682007	Marlow Scaffolding	contractor		C260830-007	08:49	Badge	Sign out

A week in. What a working site looks like: people on site, arrivals through the day, and the count still expected.

If something is wrong

The dashboard says storage is not persistent

No volume is mounted, and everything will be erased on the next deploy. Stop and fix this before anything else. Chapter 3.

The tablet shows an old version of the home screen

Kiosks check in every 20 seconds and reload when the configuration changes — but one part-way through a sign-in waits until the visitor has finished. If it is genuinely stuck, close the home-screen app and reopen it.

No camera prompt ever appears on the tablet

Open `/check/` on that tablet. It is almost always a third-party kiosk browser not forwarding the request. Use Safari with Guided Access.

"Request entry" is ticked but not showing

The card appears only once a door exists and is **enabled**. A door left disabled while it is being wired is never offered.

Teams returns a 400

The URL is probably a legacy Office 365 connector rather than a Workflows one. Create the flow again from "When an HTTP request is received".

An @-mention shows as raw markup

That person has no email address on their staff record, or one Teams cannot resolve. Add it under **Staff**.

Slides come out with words over the pictures

A font the deck used is missing on the server. Export the deck to PDF from PowerPoint and upload that instead — a PDF carries its fonts inside it and is still split into slides.

Badges print blank or half off the label

Margins None, headers and footers off, background graphics on. Then adjust the label size and text scale and print a test.

Nobody can sign in at all

There is no reset email. On the machine holding the data:

```
node scripts/reset-password.js # lists the accounts
node scripts/reset-password.js you@example.com 'a new password'
```

On Railway that is a one-off command against the service with the volume mounted. It re-enables the account and signs out every session it had.

*Day-to-day operation is in the **Front Desk Guide**. Everything this guide skipped — doors, printers, locations, the deleted-records archive, the security posture and the test suites — is in the **Administrator Guide**.*